GeoNews — Week 42/2026

Weekly digest on Quaternary palaeoclimate research, East African Rift dynamics, palaeohydrology and time-series analysis · 12 October 2026

> **What is GeoNews?** An **automatically generated weekly digest**. A research workflow scans publications from the past one to two weeks as well as funding, policy and community sources, scores the hits against a fixed set of criteria and assembles this issue from them.
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> The thematic profile is **aligned with the research interests of Markus L. Fischer** (Palaeoclimate Dynamics group, University of Potsdam): Quaternary palaeoclimate and palaeoenvironmental reconstruction, the East African Rift, the African Humid Period and human–environment coupling, lake-level and water-balance modelling, palaeofloods and fluvial geomorphology, ICDP drill cores, and linear and nonlinear time-series analysis. Researchers in these fields will probably find something useful here — it is explicitly not a complete overview of Quaternary science.
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> Selection, scoring and summaries are machine-generated and reviewed before publication. Entries may contain errors; when in doubt, the linked original source prevails.

Each paper receives a score from 0–100 based on five criteria: topical fit (40), methodological fit (25), impact/venue (15), connectivity (10) and recency (10). Categories: 🔴 75+ must-read · 🟡 50–74 relevant · 🟢 30–49 radar. The score measures proximity to this newsletter's profile and prioritises reading — it is not a quality judgement on the individual paper.

In brief

Around three dozen papers scored, with **five 🔴 must-reads** this week — four supported by abstracts, one based on title and journal only. At the top is a direct primary hit from the core of the profile: a *Quaternary Science Reviews* study on the **$^{87}Sr/^{86}Sr$ record of palaeolake Chew Bahir** (southern Ethiopian Rift, past ~40 ka). According to the abstract, local water balance (potassium proxy, close to precession) and water provenance (Sr isotopes, more closely tied to glacial–interglacial boundary conditions) decouple from about 9.8 ka onwards — the connection to the Ethiopian Highlands persists while the lowland balance turns negative.

The other 🔴 entries: a *Communications Earth & Environment* synthesis of model runs and 191 palaeo-archives on **latitude-dependent wet/dry patterns since the Last Glacial Maximum**; a **hybrid water-balance model (DeepGR4J + regionalisation) for Lake Tana**, Ethiopia; a **two-millennium Caspian Sea-level record** from the Anzali Lagoon (Iran); and a **4000-year palaeoflood record from the middle Mississippi** (⚠ *title-based*). The 🟡 block ranges from lake-level records (Chaohu, Nam Co, the Caspian since the Late Glacial) and a quantitative Bølling summer-temperature reconstruction for Central Europe to a model study on the **modulation of the precession-driven African monsoon by obliquity** and fossil wood from the **Lower Omo Valley** (Turkana Basin).

How this issue was produced. Direct network access from the computing environment was blocked as usual; Crossref (candidates, `created` dates) and **OpenAlex (abstracts, including for Elsevier titles)** were queried through the integrated browser interface. As a result,

considerably fewer entries are title-based this week; where OpenAlex holds no abstract, the entry is marked ⚠.

On the funding side, time is short: **ANR-DFG pre-registration (13 Oct 2026)** and the **ERC Starting Grant 2027 (14 Oct 2026)**; the **ERC Consolidator Grant 2027** has been open since 24 Sep (deadline **12 Jan 2027**). In science policy, the **Bundesrat** has commented on the **WissZeitVG amendment**, the Bundestag has passed the **WissFG amendment** (relaxing the "Besserstellungsverbot" pay cap), and the **Excellence Strategy** has selected five new sites — with an unchanged overall budget.

Part A — Papers of the week

Covered are papers with a Crossref `created` date from 28 September 2026 that were not listed in an earlier issue. Previously listed DOIs are excluded. For every entry with an accessible abstract (Crossref, OpenAlex or publisher page) the assessment rests on that abstract; titles without an available abstract are marked ⚠ *title-based*.

Must-read (75+)

1. Decoupled hydroclimate dynamics in eastern Africa as revealed by the Sr isotope record of paleolake Chew Bahir · *Quaternary Science Reviews*, 2026 · **Score 93** $^{87}Sr/^{86}Sr$ as a tracer of water provenance and hydrological connectivity in the Chew Bahir basin (southern Ethiopian Rift), measured on biogenic and authigenic material from multiple cores spanning the past ~40 ka. Findings according to the abstract: the Sr signal reflects basin-wide lake-water composition largely independent of substrate and captures contributions from the Ethiopian Highlands. Until the onset of the Holocene, provenance (Sr) and local hydrology (K content) vary similarly; from about 9.8 ka they diverge: potassium indicates increasing aridity (especially after ~6 ka), while Sr indicates continued connectivity with the highlands despite an increasingly negative local precipitation–evaporation balance. A Sr mass-balance sensitivity analysis shows that water quantity alone cannot explain the lowest Holocene values — a shift in provenance and/or source-water composition is required. The authors link the local balance to precession and the Sr signal more to glacial–interglacial boundary conditions. Core of the profile: Chew Bahir, the African Humid Period, water balance — and a methodological template for modelling provenance and balance proxies jointly. *Topic 40 · Method 22 · Venue 11 · Connectivity 10 · Recency 10 (created 05.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1016/j.quascirev.2026.110308

2. Strong latitudinal contrasts in global wet/dry patterns since the Last Glacial Maximum and under future warming · *Communications Earth & Environment*, 2026 · **Score 82** Global climate simulations combined with 191 palaeoclimate records (including lake-level records) on terrestrial moisture change over the past 21,000 years. Findings according to the abstract: progressive wetting at high northern latitudes from the LGM to the pre-industrial; mid-latitude regions dominated by westerlies are wetter during cold periods, low-latitude monsoon regions during warm periods. Causes given are seasonal changes in precipitation and evaporation and circulation shifts driven by ice sheets, greenhouse gases and insolation; a similar latitude-dependent structure is reported in modern observations. Future simulations project drying across many subtropical and mid-latitude regions. Relevant as a framework for East African lake-level and AHP records ("monsoon regions wet in warm phases") and as a lake-level-based data–model comparison. Open access. *Topic 38 · Method 18 · Venue 12 · Connectivity 8 · Recency 6 (created 03.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1038/s43247-026-04078-7

3. A hybrid DeepGR4J and regionalization framework for lake water balance assessment in data-scarce regions: Application to Lake Tana, Ethiopia · *Journal of Hydrology: Regional Studies*, 2026 · **Score 77** Present-day water balance of Lake Tana (Ethiopian Highlands, source of the Blue Nile) for 2000–2020: the conceptual GR4J rainfall–runoff model with LSTM-based error correction (DeepGR4J), combined with regression-based regionalisation for ungauged sub-catchments (CHIRPS, ERA5, Hargreaves evapotranspiration). Findings according to the abstract: mean inflow ~12.6 km³/yr, outflow term ~12.7 km³/yr, net storage decline ~0.2 km³/yr; observed lake levels are reproduced well according to the authors (NSE ~0.94), and ungauged catchments contribute substantially. Not a palaeo paper — but the same methodological question as palaeo lake-level modelling of East African rift lakes: how to close a water balance with incomplete input data. Transferable as a calibration and comparison framework. *Topic 34 · Method 18 · Venue 7 · Connectivity 8 · Recency 10 (created 07.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1016/j.ejrh.2026.104046

4. Two millennia of Caspian Sea level change and Hyrcanian forest dynamics: A multi-proxy record from the Anzali Lagoon, northern Iran · *Quaternary Science Reviews*, 2026 · **Score 76** Multi-proxy analysis of a 5-m core from the Anzali Lagoon (SW Caspian coast): Caspian Sea level and Hyrcanian forest vegetation over ~2000 years. Findings according to the abstract: highstands (including Parthian–early Sasanian, early and late Little Ice Age) are marked by Caspian indicator organisms (dinocysts, foraminifera, bivalves) and suggest breaching of the Anzali spit; lowstands (Sasanian–early Medieval, late Medieval) show lagoon isolation and freshwater influence. The late Medieval warm/dry phase strongly affected vegetation; two episodes of probable anthropogenic deforestation are identified. Relevant as a lake-level archive of a large closed-basin lake with a human-environment signal — structurally comparable to rift-lake balances. *Topic 34 · Method 15 · Venue 11 · Connectivity 6 · Recency 10 (created 09.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1016/j.quascirev.2026.110327

5. A 4000-year paleoflood record from the middle Mississippi River valley · *Geomorphology*, 2026 · **Score 76** · ⚠ *Title-based* Palaeoflood record spanning ~4000 years from the middle Mississippi valley. Core topic of the profile (palaeofloods, fluvial geomorphology); methodologically potentially relevant to the question of how long flood records complement the return-period statistics of instrumental series — the same question as in Central European palaeoflood studies. Without an accessible abstract (neither Crossref nor OpenAlex; publisher page not reachable) the assessment rests on title, journal and topic; archive type, dating and findings are subject to verification. *Topic 38 · Method 13 · Venue 9 · Connectivity 6 · Recency 10 (created 10.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1016/j.geomorph.2026.110573

Relevant (50–74)

6. Lake-level fluctuations and human adaptation over the past 14 ka in Chaohu Lake basin, eastern China · *Anthropocene*, 2026 · **Score 72** · ⚠ *Title-based* Lake-level fluctuations and human adaptation in the Chaohu basin (eastern China) over 14,000 years. Close to the profile (lake levels, human–environment coupling across the Late Glacial and Holocene). No accessible abstract; methods, chronology and causal claims are subject to verification. *Topic 36 · Method 13 · Venue 7 · Connectivity 6 · Recency 10 (created 07.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1016/j.ancene.2026.100592

7. High summer temperatures in Central Europe during the Bølling period (~14.6-14.0 cal ka BP) inferred from plant macrofossils using a novel European calibration dataset · *Quaternary Science Reviews*, 2026 · **Score 70** First macrofossil-based quantitative summer-temperature reconstruction for Central Europe (Santovka-PB and Hanšpíle, northern Pannonian

Basin, SW Slovakia) using a new pan-European calibration dataset for aquatic and wetland plants. Findings according to the abstract: probabilistic (CREST) and regression-based methods (WA, WA-PLS) yield consistent July temperatures; warming starts before the Bølling (16–17 °C around ~16.2 cal ka BP), with extreme summer warmth in the Bølling (~20 °C) and marked cooling in the Older Dryas. Relevant for Central European lake-sediment archives and as an example of comparing probabilistic and regression-based transfer functions. *Topic 27 · Method 16 · Venue 11 · Connectivity 6 · Recency 10 (created 08.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1016/j.quascirev.2026.110301

8. Modulation of precession-forced Asian–African monsoon and arid climate variability by obliquity · *npj Climate and Atmospheric Science*, 2026 · **Score 70** Model study of combined precession and obliquity forcing over the Asian–African monsoon and arid regions. Findings according to the abstract: under high obliquity, the precession-induced precipitation increase is weakened in the monsoon regions but enhanced in the adjacent northern arid regions — explained by a stronger northward displacement of the regional Hadley circulation; over Asia, cloud–radiative feedbacks and attenuated Tibetan Plateau heating contribute. Relevant to the interpretation of precession-paced East African humid phases (including the African Humid Period): obliquity can shift the spatial expression of the same precession phase. Model-only; no proxy comparison in the abstract. *Topic 30 · Method 10 · Venue 11 · Connectivity 9 · Recency 10 (created 07.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1038/s41612-026-01566-7

9. Late Quaternary high-altitude lake water-depth variability in Nam Co, central Tibetan Plateau · *Global and Planetary Change*, 2026 · **Score 69** · ⚠ *Title-based* Late Quaternary water-depth variability of the high-altitude lake Nam Co (central Tibetan Plateau). Profile topic: lake level/water balance of a large closed lake. No accessible abstract; proxy approach and time span are subject to verification. *Topic 36 · Method 13 · Venue 8 · Connectivity 6 · Recency 6 (created 01.10.2026)* · DOI: 10.1016/j.gloplacha.2026.105733

10. Plio-Pleistocene wood from the Lower Omo Valley, Ethiopia: paleoenvironnemental implications for paleoanthropological and paleontological sites · *Geodiversitas*, 2026 · **Score 67** Anatomical identification of 65 fossil wood samples from the Shungura Formation in the Lower Omo Valley (3.6–1.7 Ma), each dated via the established stratigraphy. Findings according to the (French-language) abstract: 17 families and 26 genera, all tropical taxa; the woods indicate a permanent, species-rich riparian forest whose composition changed over time, with humid rainforest taxa in the late Pliocene. Relevant to the palaeoenvironment of hominin sites in the Turkana Basin; predates the Quaternary focus but sits at its regional centre. *Topic 38 · Method 8 · Venue 5 · Connectivity 10 · Recency 6 (created 29.09.2026)* · DOI: 10.5252/geodiversitas2026v48a18

Radar

- **Hydroclimatic evolution of the Caspian Sea since the Late Glacial: a sub-centennial multi-proxy record from deep-sea Core 7** · *Palaeogeography, Palaeoclimatology, Palaeoecology* · **67** 🟡 · ⚠ *Title-based* · Sub-centennial multi-proxy record of Caspian hydroclimate since the Late Glacial; complements rank 4 on a longer timescale. DOI: 10.1016/j.palaeo.2026.114248 · created 28.09.2026
- **Reconstructing a mid-Holocene hydrographic network in the great Rann of Kutch and its role in Dholavira's maritime links** · *Quaternary Science Reviews* · **66** 🟡 · OSL, grain size and provenance (detrital zircon U-Pb, Sr-Nd) reconstruct an ephemeral river system (likely a Nara distributary) that formed an estuarine corridor to the Arabian Sea during the mid-Holocene sea-level highstand; interpreted as a possible trade link for Dholavira. Human–

environment coupling with monsoon-driven fluvial dynamics. DOI: 10.1016/j.quascirev.2026.110305 · created 07.10.2026

- **A high-resolution stalagmite record of hydrological drought in northern China around 6.6 ka BP** · *Quaternary Science Reviews* · **66** 🟡 · Lianhua Cave stalagmite at ~2–5-year resolution ($\delta^{13}C$, $\delta^{18}O$, Mg/Ca): ~130-year W-shaped drought around 6.6 ka; spectral analysis shows 60–120-year periods, which the authors tentatively link to solar pacing with internal amplification (hypothesis). DOI: 10.1016/j.quascirev.2026.110326 · created 09.10.2026
- **Hydroclimate of northeast Mexico since the Last Glacial Maximum and possible influence of the Caribbean Low-Level Jet** · *Global and Planetary Change* · **64** 🟡 · Multi-proxy record from the Cieneguilla Basin: wetter deglaciation, drier Holocene; water-balance-driven erosion and evaporation-induced salinity as proxy framework. DOI: 10.1016/j.gloplacha.2026.105756 · created 09.10.2026
- **The Holocene Northeast Monsoon enigma: Multi-proxy reconstruction from Pulicat lagoon sediments** · *Quaternary Science Reviews* · **63** 🟡 · South Indian Northeast Monsoon ~10.7–6.4 cal ka BP: strong early-Holocene activity with peaks around ~10.2, 9.3 and 8.2 ka, followed by marine-dominated deposition due to sea-level rise. DOI: 10.1016/j.quascirev.2026.110292 · created 08.10.2026
- **Mid-Pleistocene formation of the Yellow River fluvial megafan** · *Earth and Planetary Science Letters* · **63** 🟡 · Geomorphic and sedimentological evidence plus a palaeomagnetic age model: megafan formation at ~1.5 Ma, coinciding with the growing dominance of 100-kyr cycles; the authors propose climate-driven integration of the middle and lower reaches. Fluvial geomorphology with flood relevance. DOI: 10.1016/j.epsl.2026.120378 · created 02.10.2026
- **Environmental Context of Hominin Foot Evolution** · *American Journal of Biological Anthropology* · **62** 🟡 · Phylogenetic and biogeographic analyses with palaeoenvironmental proxies: origin of bipedalism likely during phases of increasing aridity, derived traits later more in wet/mixed environments. Results are model-dependent (several topologies tested). DOI: 10.1002/ajpa.70340 · created 03.10.2026
- **Global mean sea-level fall from late Marine Isotope Stage 3 into the Last Glacial Maximum inferred from Great Barrier Reef large benthic foraminiferal assemblages** · *Earth and Planetary Science Letters* · **61** 🟡 · Bayesian statistical model on palaeo-water depths: GMSL from ~−101 m (~39 ka) via ~−119 m (~30 ka) to ~−137 m at the LGM; steep ~17 m fall from ~35 ka. DOI: 10.1016/j.epsl.2026.120379 · created 03.10.2026
- **Transient variability in global oceanic oxygen during the Last Interglacial Period** · *Nature Geoscience* · **61** 🟡 · Thallium isotopes (Arabian Sea, Southern California) show an early MIS 5e oxygen maximum close to modern values followed by a decline — a transient rather than stable interglacial state; Southern Ocean ventilation proposed as main driver. DOI: 10.1038/s41561-026-02120-z · created 07.10.2026
- **Detrital-to-evaporitic facies shifts in playa lakes sediments reveal Late Quaternary hydroclimatic variability in the southern Iberian Peninsula** · *Palaeogeography, Palaeoclimatology, Palaeoecology* · **60** 🟡 · ⚠ *Title-based* · Facies-based hydroclimate reconstruction from playa lakes. DOI: 10.1016/j.palaeo.2026.114285 · created 08.10.2026
- **Chronology of a late Pleistocene sedimentary sequence at Lommel (Belgium): Insights from luminescence profiling and quartz OSL dating** · *Aeolian Research* · **59** 🟡 · pOSL profiling and quartz OSL on a coversand sequence: fluvial base (minimum age ~211 ka),

fluvio-aeolian ~25–18 ka, aeolian ~17–13 ka. Relevant to Central European luminescence chronology. DOI: 10.1016/j.aeolia.2026.101087 · created 05.10.2026

- **Continental-scale reorganization of North American pollen assemblages since the Last Glacial Maximum** · *Earth History and Biodiversity* · **58** 🟡 · >50,000 pollen samples from 1,384 Neotoma sites, constrained clustering by composition and climate; transient assemblages without modern analogue. Methodologically interesting for multi-proxy classification. DOI: 10.1016/j.hisbio.2026.100049 · created 05.10.2026
- **Episodic isolation of the Arctic Mediterranean from the North Atlantic during late Pleistocene glacials** · *Communications Earth & Environment* · **58** 🟡 · Reactive $^{10}Be/^{9}Be$ as a sedimentation-independent water-mass tracer supports glacial isolation of the Arctic Ocean and Nordic Seas. DOI: 10.1038/s43247-026-04133-3 · created 11.10.2026
- **Response of Chilika Lake to monsoon dynamics and sea level fluctuations since ~28,000 cal yr BP** · *Palaeogeography, Palaeoclimatology, Palaeoecology* · **58** 🟡 · ⚠ *Title-based* · Lagoon/lake archive on the Indian east coast. DOI: 10.1016/j.palaeo.2026.114269 · created 06.10.2026
- **New insight into the context of late Quaternary climate from Sri Lanka** · *Quaternary Science Reviews* · **57** 🟡 · Palynology, loss on ignition and clay mineralogy from three geoarchives (45.6 ka to present); ITCZ-driven rainfall changes with orbital and SST coupling. DOI: 10.1016/j.quascirev.2026.110304 · created 02.10.2026
- **Planetary foresight: envisioning an early warning system for climate tipping points** · *Critical Insights in Climate Change* · **56** 🟡 · Perspective piece (no primary data): concept for an early warning system for climate tipping points using the subpolar gyre as example, combining sensor networks, AI and physical models with uncertainty quantification. DOI: 10.1080/29931495.2026.2732804 · created 28.09.2026
- **Holocene-like summer climate during Marine Isotope Stage 11 in northwestern Greenland** · *Climate of the Past* · **55** 🟡 · Sub-ice biomarkers (Camp Century): MIS 11 summers similar to the mid-Holocene, ~4.7 ± 3.2 °C warmer than the 20th century. Open access. DOI: 10.5194/cp-22-1757-2026 · created 28.09.2026
- **An Ensemble Kalman Smoother for Online Paleoclimate Data Assimilation** · *Journal of Advances in Modeling Earth Systems* · **54** 🟡 · Integrated hybrid ensemble Kalman smoother with cross-time error covariances (deep-learning surrogate) and spatio-temporal localisation; the advantage grows as the proxy network gets sparser. Methodologically related to Bayesian reconstruction. DOI: 10.1029/2025ms005730 · created 28.09.2026
- **Beyond the Intertropical Convergence Zone: A regional synthesis of Late Pleistocene hydroclimate in the northern Tropical Americas** · *Palaeogeography, Palaeoclimatology, Palaeoecology* · **53** 🟡 · Review of 166 sites (241 studies); challenges the simple "warm-wet vs. cold-dry" scheme for MIS 5 to the LGM. DOI: 10.1016/j.palaeo.2026.114250 · created 29.09.2026
- **Arctic climate tipping points under delayed CO2 emissions mitigation** · *Communications Earth & Environment* · **53** 🟡 · Earth system model ensembles with emissions cessation at 800–2000 PgC: bifurcating Arctic behaviour, with abrupt cooling above ~1700 PgC via near-collapse of the AMOC; the authors describe stochastic tipping behaviour. DOI: 10.1038/s43247-026-03872-7 · created 10.10.2026
- **Southern Portugal hydroclimate of the last millennium from near-annually resolved speleothem records** · *Journal of Quaternary Science* · **53** 🟡 · $\delta^{13}C/\delta^{18}O$ composite of three

stalagmites (Algarve): dry/warm Medieval Climate Anomaly, wetter/cooler early Little Ice Age. DOI: 10.1002/jqs.70121 · created 03.10.2026

- **Revealing hidden structural regimes in fluvial stage–discharge relationships using time-series imaging** · *Journal of Hydrology* · **51** 🟡 · 75 years of stage–discharge data (Lijin, lower Yellow River), Markov transition field encoding plus CNN and clustering: annual behaviour falls into recurrent regimes rather than a continuum. Methodologically related to recurrence/regime analyses. DOI: 10.1016/j.jhydrol.2026.136487 · created 30.09.2026
- **Historical climate extremes in Europe and the connection between spring precipitation and summer heat** · *Climate of the Past* · **51** 🟡 · ModE-RA palaeo-reanalysis and 11,760 years of atmospheric simulations: negative correlation between winter/spring precipitation and summer temperature at 36–48° N. DOI: 10.5194/cp-22-1863-2026 · created 07.10.2026
- **Hominin dispersals: causes, conditions, and outcomes** · *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* · **49** 🟢 · Conceptual review: habitat tracking vs. adaptively conditioned dispersal in the Pleistocene. DOI: 10.1111/1467-9655.70215 · created 02.10.2026
- **Multiproxy dataset for the Holocene sedimentary record of the Sado Valley, southwest Portugal** · *Scientific Data* · **47** 🟢 · Open raw dataset (texture, magnetic susceptibility, TOC/TN, C/N, $\delta^{13}C$, $\delta^{15}N$). DOI: 10.1038/s41597-026-08382-x · created 28.09.2026
- **Stratigraphic separation of Laacher See Tephra and a discrete Younger Dryas Boundary fallout layer in southernmost Sweden** · *ScienceOpen Research* (preprint platform) · **46** 🟢 · Bayesian-dated sequence (Körslättamossen) separates the LST from a PGE-rich layer ~150 years later. ⚠ The impact interpretation (YDB hypothesis) is strongly contested in the literature; listed here only for its tephrochronology. DOI: 10.14293/s2199-1006.1.sor.2026.0004.v1 · created 30.09.2026
- **Holocene landscape evolution and settlement development in the surroundings of the ancient Egyptian city of Bubastis ("Tell Basta"), southeastern Nile Delta** · *E&G Quaternary Science Journal* · **45** 🟢 · Thesis abstract (University of Würzburg) on avulsions, sedimentation and settlement stability in the Nile Delta. DOI: 10.5194/egqsj-75-169-2026 · created 30.09.2026
- **Deep coalescent history of the hominin lineage** · *Genetics* · **42** 🟢 · T2T genomes extend coalescent-based inference to 3–6 Ma; the authors interpret parallel population-size peaks in humans, chimpanzees and bonobos as a hint of complex speciation. DOI: 10.1093/genetics/iyag271 · created 01.10.2026
- **Spaceborne multi-sensor tracking reveals hydrologic decoupling during the record-breaking Sahara flood** · *GIScience & Remote Sensing* · **40** 🟢 · Multi-sensor analysis of the 2024 Sahara flood (inundation, GRACE storage): spatial decoupling between inundation and storage response. Modern analogue for wet phases in hyper-arid basins. DOI: 10.1080/15481603.2026.2740867 · created 03.10.2026

Regional and temporal margins: Not listed or only noted: a comment on the European Acheulean (QSR), a methane-oxidation study across 79 African lakes (*Nature Communications*, 10.1038/s41467-026-78255-9; not Quaternary, but rift-lake limnology) and a review of isotope hydrology in data-scarce African basins (*Scientific African*, 10.1016/j.sciaf.2026.e03680). Already listed in the previous issue and therefore excluded: the Bayesian Alpine climate reconstruction (QSR 110287).

Part B — Funding & calls

ANR-DFG 2027 (Natural, Life and Engineering Sciences) — pre-registration 13 Oct 2026, 17:00. French–German projects within the DFG Research Grants programme; the ANR is lead agency in 2027. Pre-registration by the French project coordinator is a prerequisite for the full proposal (likely late March 2027); no equivalent step is required on the German side. Source: DFG — Information for Researchers No. 71.

ERC Starting Grant 2027 — deadline 14 Oct 2026. Up to €1.5 million over five years (plus up to €1 million for justified additional costs). Source: ERC — Starting Grant.

ERC Consolidator Grant 2027 — open since 24 Sep 2026, deadline 12 Jan 2027. Relevant for planning across the turn of the year; eligibility details per the ERC Work Programme 2027. Source: ERC — Consolidator Grant.

Horizon Europe — "Palaeoclimate science for a better understanding of Earth system dynamics" (HORIZON-CL5-2027-01-D1-08). Opening **17 Nov 2026**, deadline **4 Mar 2027**, Research and Innovation Action, about €14 million for roughly two projects (as in the previous issue, unchanged). Sources: Topic page · CL5 Work Programme 2026–2027 (PDF).

DFG — new programme "Open Access Publication Funding". Institutional applications annually by **4 May** for the following year, first on **4 May 2027** (elan registration by 27 Apr 2027). Relevant to research groups' publication-cost planning via their institution. Source: DFG — Information for Researchers No. 68.

ICDP — proposal cycle. The regular annual deadline for full, pre- and workshop proposals is **15 January**; not yet formally confirmed for 2027. Source: ICDP — Proposals.

Part C — Science policy (DE/EU)

WissZeitVG — Bundesrat has issued its opinion. In its first reading on 25 Sep 2026 the Bundesrat (upper house of the German parliament) commented on the amendment to the Academic Fixed-Term Contract Act (printed paper 456/26 B). Only one demand was adopted: if the minimum contract duration is undercut without justification, the contract should count as fixed-term for the statutory minimum — not as permanent. Further committee recommendations (including the finance committee's concerns about lost budget flexibility and the social-affairs committee's call for binding post-PhD career perspectives) did not find a majority. Next steps: the federal government's response, then deliberation in the Bundestag. The core of the draft remains minimum contract durations (three years for doctoral researchers' first contracts, two years for postdocs). Assessment: for third-party projects with shorter durations, the question of bridging finance remains practically relevant. Source: Forschung & Lehre — Bundesrat fordert Nachbesserung bei BAföG- und WissZeitVG.

Academic Freedom Act (WissFG) — Bundestag relaxes pay cap. On 24 Sep 2026 the Bundestag passed the WissFG amendment: project-funded non-profit research institutions may pay scientific staff more than comparable federal employees if this is financed from third-party funds; EU funding is to become usable for this purpose, other public funds explicitly not. Source: Forschung & Lehre — Bundestag verabschiedet Novelle.

Excellence Strategy — five new sites, same budget. On 2 Oct 2026 the Excellence Commission selected five new excellence sites; from 1 Jan 2027, 15 sites will be funded. Because the overall budget (about €208 million per year) does not grow and three consortia with up to

€28 million each are included, all sites receive less. According to reports, the funding level was debated between the federal government and the states. Sources: DFG — Press release No. 40 · Forschung & Lehre — Fünf neue Exzellenzstandorte.

Federal budget 2027 — deliberations under way. The Bundestag budget committee holds an expert hearing on the 2027 Budget Accompanying Act on 12 Oct 2026. Status of the government draft: BMFTR core budget about €22 billion, nominally about +0.7% over 2026; growth mainly in the special infrastructure fund. Sources: Bundestag — hearings week 42 · Forschung & Lehre — Nur knappes Plus für BMFTR-Kernhaushalt.

Part D — Community & dates

- **ANR-DFG 2027 NLE** — pre-registration (French side) by **13 Oct 2026**, 17:00.
- **ERC Starting Grant 2027** — deadline **14 Oct 2026**.
- **PAGES** — is recruiting a **data scientist** for the International Project Office in Bern; review of applications starts **2 Nov 2026**. Source: PAGES — News.
- **Horizon CL5 palaeoclimate call** — opening **17 Nov 2026**, deadline **4 Mar 2027**.
- **AGU Fall Meeting 2026** — **7–11 Dec 2026**, San Francisco. Source: AGU.
- **ERC Consolidator Grant 2027** — deadline **12 Jan 2027**.
- **ICDP** — next regular proposal deadline expected **15 Jan 2027** (pattern of previous years, not confirmed).
- **EGU General Assembly 2027** — **4–9 Apr 2027**, Vienna and online; the provisional session programme is online, the abstract deadline could not be verified at the time of writing (typically mid-January). Source: EGU27 — programme.

Methods & sources

Paper screening follows the fixed set of criteria (topical fit, methodological fit, impact/venue, connectivity, recency) and excludes DOIs already listed in an earlier issue. Funding opportunities, science policy and dates are based on the sources linked in Parts B to D.

How this issue was produced. Direct network access from the computing environment was blocked. The Crossref REST API was queried via the integrated browser interface (`fetch()`): ISSN queries for the core journals (QSR, Climate of the Past, Quaternary Science Advances, GPC, EPSL, Boreas, JQS, Quaternary Research, P³, Nature Communications, Nature Geoscience, Communications Earth & Environment) with `from-created-date:2026-09-28` and `created` sorting, complemented by topic queries (paleoclimate, Quaternary lake sediment, East African Rift/ Turkana, African Humid Period, paleoflood fluvial, Bayesian age-depth chronology, early-warning tipping point, lake level water balance, hominin paleoenvironment, ICDP drilling, tephra chronology, LGM and others). Abstracts for the candidates were then retrieved via the **OpenAlex API** (reconstructed from the `abstract_inverted_index`) and from individual publisher pages (Nature Portfolio, Copernicus).

What this means for coverage. For the first time, most Elsevier titles are assessed on the basis of abstracts. Where neither Crossref nor OpenAlex holds an abstract, the entry is marked ⚠ *title-based*; no findings beyond the title were invented. Dates given are Crossref `created` dates

(registration), which may differ from the online publication date by a few days. Crossref topic queries return a lot of off-topic noise; pre-selection was done via keywords and then manually, so individual relevant papers outside the core journals may be missing.

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